

Regaining control

THERE WERE QUITE A FEW EVENTS THIS MONTH that managed to trigger the paranoia in me. The first was everyone's favourite browser, Chrome. Update 69, the newest incarnation of the devil has begun logging you into the browser automatically without any notification or consent if you login to any of their webservices. Did you just sign into Gmail? Check your Chrome settings and you'll show up as logged in. Now, I only use Chrome for a few applications but this is unnerving to say the least. I don't want a customised SERP (Search Engine Results Page) nor do I want any of the value added services (read targeted advertising) that Google wants to push down my throat. With Google's web service logins such as that of Gmail being merged with the browser, Google has effectively gained access to my browsing history. I realise that there's no point in harping about privacy but witnessing a gross violation in such a blatant manner is unnerving. It's not like I'm freeloading off of Google. I pay for extra drive space, so I don't want Google selling me ads. So, I'm ditching Google Chrome as one of my frequently used browsers in favour of something new. If you're wondering who the likely replacement will be, then good ol' Firefox seems to be a good candidate.

It's not just my browser, even the OS has been problematic in the same vein. With every new update Windows removes some of the maintenance apps that I use without giving any notifications. Don't even get me started on the telemetry services. There's no telling when Windows will sneakily turn some of them back on. If it weren't for all the games on Steam and some work related software, I would have made the switch to Linux already. In fact, the latest Ubuntu LTS release (Bionic Beaver 18.04.1) came out a couple of days back so I might as well give it a go and see how things have improved over the last two years. Yes, it's been that long since I've used Linux on my desktop. Last I checked, gaming on Linux has improved by a huge fold. Also, most of the games that I play for the sake of reviews is on a test bench, so it's not as if I'm married to using Windows. I can always have a dual-boot OS setup for when I absolutely have to use Microsoft's spawn. So you'll probably see a bit more Linux related content from us in the coming months.

Even my phone is a concern from the privacy perspective. While the UI on the POCO F1 is vastly different from most of Xiaomi's devices, it's still not great. That's to say, it's still not stock. I've stripped down most of the 'niceties' that shipped with the device and brought it down to near stock state. It was a painful process of manual elimination wherein I had to nuke packages on the device while hoping that it wouldn't get bricked. At the end of a long and arduous process, I ended up removing 46 packages which were absolutely unnecessary for my use case. That's not a small number by any means. There's no telling how many of them were siphoning your data to unknown foreign servers. You might be wondering why I haven't put a custom ROM or a GSI. Well, the only reason I haven't put a GSI on it is because none of the images out there right now have both radios fully functional. I'm really glad that Google decided to implement Project Treble. This way users don't have to deal with the unnecessary bloatware that ships with the devices out of the box.

I don't know about you guys but having control stripped away from any software or device ticks me off. In the pre-broadband days, this wasn't a major concern but with the current level of internet penetration companies are getting a little too familiar with the average user. Not that operating systems were awesome back then but you'd focus more on slimming the OS down for the sake of extracting every iota of extra performance you could. Now, you have to do that and strip all sorts of tracking and telemetry packages that are installed on your machines to siphon your data without your consent. Which is why I'm all for a GDPR-like regulation to be enforced as soon as possible because even these companies know that such a regulation is inevitable in the long run. Most of us couldn't care less about how GDPR has stifled innovation. If your 'innovative' product is built on the basis of violating someone's right to privacy, then I don't think your product should see the light of day. So this is the best time to extract as much data as they can from countries with poor regulation before the doors slam shut. The government has set a nice precedent with Net Neutrality, I just hope that digital privacy is next on their agenda.



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